



THE HIVE Fertility Clinic & Women’s Centre



The Light at the End of the Tunnel

Haarshini Agarwal

Loss always feels bittersweet. Bitter because the void of the loss is always felt, no matter what; Sweet because it, somewhere in its small way, drives you and teaches you to be better in life. This is true in any stage of life, be it the loss of a doll or the loss of a growing fetus in the womb of a mother.

For a woman who is trying to experience motherhood and has experienced recurrent pregnancy loss, she will be bewildered by a positive pregnancy test, as her celebration will end at the burning question: What if it happens again?

Recurrent pregnancy loss is a deeply emotional experience, but it is important to remember that it does not mean the possibility of a successful pregnancy has come to an end. In fact, many women who experience repeated miscarriages eventually go on to have healthy pregnancies and children. After one loss, people may offer comfort and reassurance. After a second or third, the questions can become more difficult. Couples may begin to wonder if they did something wrong or whether their dream of becoming parents is slipping further away. The truth is that miscarriage is rarely caused by something a woman did or failed to do.

Pregnancy loss may be linked to genetics that might show up randomly during the pregnancy. In other cases, health conditions or certain problems with the uterus may play a role. There are also instances where doctors are unable to find a definite reason, even after detailed evaluation.

That uncertainty may not have an immediate answer, but it does not mean there is no way forward. A careful evaluation can help doctors understand a couple's medical history, identify possible factors and decide what kind of care may be helpful in a future pregnancy. Regular consultations can provide reassurance, while having a clear plan can help reduce some of the uncertainty that follows previous losses. Just as important is recognising the emotional toll of the experience.

Grief after a miscarriage does not follow a timeline. They may be happy about a new pregnancy and anxious at the same time. Both emotions can exist together. Counselling, support groups, and conversations with trusted people can help couples process the loss rather than feel pressured to move on.

Perhaps the most important message is this: a history of loss is not a prediction of the future. Every pregnancy is different. While the journey may require patience, evaluation and support, many couples do eventually welcome a healthy baby.

Hope after loss, sometimes, is simply finding the courage to seek answers. Sometimes, it is allowing oneself to try again while still carrying the memory of what happened before. And sometimes, it is understanding that fear and hope can coexist.

For couples facing recurrent pregnancy loss, the road ahead may be uncertain but not hopeless. With compassionate care, the right support and time, there can still be a future that looks very different from the past.

When Hope Becomes Another Thing to Carry

Siddhi Nawar

Most of us grow up learning how to try again. As children, we are handed phrases: “never give up”, “do your best”, “failure is a stepping stone to success”. Over time, this language of relentless positivity asks us to keep moving, keep trying and eventually overcome whatever life places in our way.

But what happens when the challenge is not solved through constant perseverance? What happens when the challenge is a pregnancy that does not continue, an IVF cycle that does not result in implantation, or the repeated heartbreak of recurrent implantation failure?

For these experiences, there is no neat manual for grieving a baby that never came to be, or for navigating the emotional exhaustion of yet another unsuccessful embryo transfer. And while people are quick to offer advice, “try again, don't lose hope, it will happen”, there is far less conversation about the emotional cost of having to hope repeatedly.

What is Recurrent Implantation Failure?

Recurrent implantation failure (RIF) refers to repeated instances in which an embryo does not implant in the uterus following IVF or embryo transfer. While there is no universally accepted definition of the condition, doctors may consider factors such as the number of unsuccessful transfers, embryo quality and the individual circumstances of the patient before assessing a case as RIF.

Doctors in the field of IVF report that patients often arrive with a great deal of emotional exhaustion by the time they are evaluated for recurrent implantation failure. The challenge is not only to investigate the possible medical reasons, but also to recognise what repeated disappointment has done to the person and the couple.

Implantation itself is a complex process, influenced by an individual's case, embryo-related factors, the health and receptivity of the uterine lining, hormonal and metabolic factors, and certain structural or genetic considerations. However, not every failed implantation has a clear or identifiable cause. That



uncertainty can make the experience particularly difficult, leaving patients searching for answers.

The Idea of Failure

The emotional impact of a recurrent implantation failure is grief, anxiety, anger, guilt and helplessness. For some, every pregnancy announcement or baby shower around them is a reminder of what they are still waiting for. The language of “failure” can further complicate this experience, making patients feel that they have personally failed, when implantation is influenced by a complex interaction of biological factors.

This is why care for RIF must extend beyond medical investigations and treatment plans. Counselling, mental health support and honest communication with partners can be important parts of the journey. Patients can also benefit from asking their doctors what is known, what remains uncertain and which investigations are genuinely relevant to their individual history.

Most importantly, a failed IVF cycle is not a personal failure. Neither is the natural human process of needing time to grieve, pause or reconsider what comes next.

For those experiencing recurrent implantation failure, the journey can feel uniquely lonely, especially in a society that often mistakes optimism for resilience and persistence for the only acceptable response to disappointment. Sometimes, compassionate care begins by acknowledging that not every loss needs to be immediately transformed into a lesson, and not every person needs to be told to try again before they have had the chance to grieve.



Bringing Hope and Creating Families with THE HIVE

For thousands of couples, the journey to parenthood begins with the right guidance, compassionate care and advanced fertility treatment. With over 15 years of expertise, THE HIVE Fertility Centre & Women's Centre has emerged as one of Chennai's trusted fertility care providers, offering ethical, evidence-based and personalised fertility solutions.

With an 80 percent success rate, the trust of over 67,000 families and more than 52,000 happy babies, THE HIVE provides comprehensive care across eight centres in Chennai. Every treatment plan is tailored to individual needs following detailed evaluation and expert guidance.

Beyond clinical care, initiatives such as the Good News Campaign support couples trying to conceive naturally, while online second-opinion consultations extend expert guidance to patients across India and abroad.

At THE HIVE, advanced technology meets compassionate care, helping couples navigate their fertility journey with confidence, clarity and hope.

Where Every Journey Towards Parenthood Begins with Hope.



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A seven-foot shibori canopy hangs overhead, suspended like a monsoon cloud. Dyed in deep blues and greens, it filters across the white walls of a 60-year-old Chennai home, casting shadows that evoke the rhythm of rain through the dye of the cloth and its geometry.

The immersive setup forms the backdrop of Studio Medium's pre-festive 2026 collection, Beat Repeat, recently unveiled at Collage in Chennai and hosted by architect and interior designer Gowri Adappa. Featuring saris, kurtas, dresses, kaftans and shirts, the collection explores the intersection of architecture and textiles, where the process of making is placed on an equal footing with the finished garment.

Inspired by geometry
For founders Riddhi Jain and Dhruv Satija, the collection began with the simple but enduring element – water.

“Since the very beginning, we have been working with various dyeing techniques,” says Riddhi. “The primary part of the process is that you restrict water from certain areas to create a pattern,” she says, adding “What’s amazing about the rain and our textile-making process is that it’s unpredictable but you can still plan for it.”

The collection is monsoon in all its forms: circular motifs, eco raindrops and expanding ripples, which are translated across bandhani, arashi, shibori and mothra techniques. The colour palette shifts from burgundy, rani, greens, blues, red and navy, mirroring skies before and after rainfall.

“Rain has been an inspiration, but we have also been inspired by the sound of it, the music of it, by what it leads to and the patterns it creates. We tried to bring that into the patterns,” says Riddhi



Saris shaped by rain

Studio Medium channels the monsoons for Beat Repeat

Central to the installations is a *pateela*, an element that keeps emerging in almost all

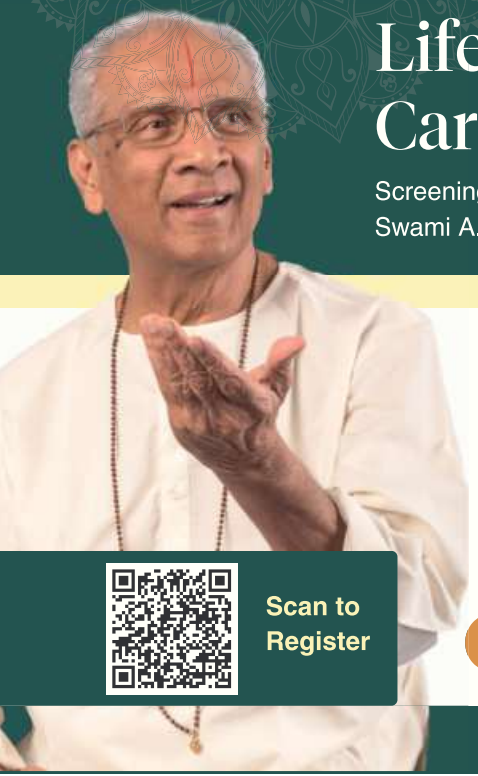
their collections. “A lot of our work comes from dyeing, and this is where it happens.

(From far left) An outfit from Beat Repeat; and Riddhi Jain and Dhruv Satija.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

This is a tool of transformation,” says Dhruv. Architecture has become an equally significant influence on the studio’s design language. “We rely on three basic forms – the square, the circle and the triangle – and so does architecture. Without these forms, there is nothing,” says Dhruv. The collection has been developed in collaboration with master craftspeople across Gujarat and Bengal alongside Studio Medium’s atelier in New Delhi.

The collection is on at Collage, Rutland Gate and is priced from ₹21,500 onwards.





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pick of the week



Metal mayhem

Turn the volume all the way up this weekend. Brutal Carnage XVI returns to Chennai with Trivandrum's CHAOS headlining the night and launching their new album, *Bane of Humanity*. The line-up also features progressive metal outfit Incendiarius, alternative punk-rock act MANGAS ahead of the musician's overseas move, and metalcore project Drumtoid. *Catch the action at The Spotted Deer, Hotel Palomar, on August 1 from 6pm.*



Life, love, laughter

Fatherhood, first loves, family chaos, and failed gym motivation — Aashish Solanki turns life's latest plot twists into comedy gold in his new stand-up special. The former Math teacher swaps equations for parenting puzzles, sibling rivalry, and baffling family moments in an hour packed with sharp observations and relatable humour. *Catch him live at Rasika Ranjani Sabha, on July 25 at 7.30pm. Tickets start at ₹499 at bookmyshow.com*



Suit up Spidey

Calling all Spider-Man fans! Slip into the Spider-Verse for an evening filled with trivia, games, exclusive trailer screenings, and fan conversations. Pick up free goodies, meet fellow web-slingers, and get a chance to win an IMAX ticket to *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*. Whether you are team Peter, Miles or MJ, the event is your chance to meet fellow nerds. *July 26, 4pm onwards. Tickets for ₹199 at kynhood.com.*



Curry chronicles

Hop across the Indian Ocean without leaving Chennai at Island Spice Trail at Mynt, Vivanta Chennai IT Expressway. Feast on Sri Lankan and Maldivian favourites including garudhiya, polos ambula, Sri Lankan devilled chicken, kandu kukulu, Negombu prawn curry, and finish with watalappam and crisp kokkis. *Available until July 26 for lunch and dinner on weekends, and dinner on weekdays. For reservation, call 66802500.*

S Poorvaja

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Beneath sculptural orbs suspended from the ceiling, meant to evoke the sun and the moon, dancers emerged, lithe and graceful. It is Delhi couturier Gaurav Gupta's way of setting the mood before guests enter the main hall at the Jio World Convention Centre on last week for his bridal couture showcase.

In collaboration with auto brand MG Select, this is the second year in a row that Gaurav has skipped Paris Couture Week in July to unveil an elaborate bridal collection in Mumbai. When we speak to him a day before the show, he is at his atelier, in Mumbai's Kala Ghoda, overseeing fittings for more than 70 looks spanning bridal couture, menswear, cocktail dressing and occasion wear. "A large collection this time," he says.

For Light Song, Gaurav did not have to look far for inspiration.

"My brand has always been rooted in fantasy, cosmology and mythology. We keep revisiting these themes because that's the mindspace I'm in. Light Song came from cosmology. I created my own story around the romance between the sun and the moon, and their complementary energies," he says.

When asked about the recent "inspiration" debate surrounding his sculpted breastplate designs, Gaurav is quick to point out that inspiration belongs to no one person. "Sometimes these beautiful accidents happen," he says.

The collection unfolded across three acts – Solar, Lunar and Cosmic Union – each distinct in design yet tied together by a single narrative.

The Lunar act draws on moonlight, lunar energy and mythology. Evening gowns and cocktail dresses with sweeping trains appear in shimmering black, Gaurav's signature midnight blue – his preferred alternative to black – and ivy grey. Texture takes centrestage: moon craters are recreated

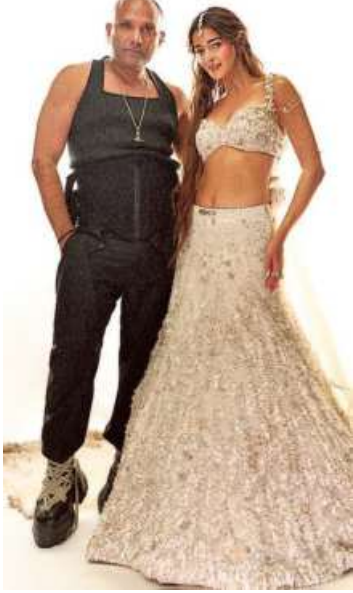
At home with the cosmos
Gaurav Gupta's Light Song, foregrounds craftsmanship, and revisits the brand's enduring design codes



through intricate bugle beadwork. The Solar act shifted to bridal lehengas, saris and sharply tailored jackets with power shoulders paired with shararas, rendered in zardozi, gold, champagne and rich red tones.

While Gaurav is widely associated with sculptural couture, he says he deliberately dialled it back this season. "We've used

(Clockwise from left) Light Song on the ramp; and Gaurav Gupta with actor Ananya Panday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



sculpting only where it naturally fits because our Paris collections already offer plenty of those options for clients around the world. I wanted people to recognise the craftsmanship and engineering behind the embroidery, draping, silhouettes and metalwork. That's couture too."

As a bridal collection, much of it feels familiar. The silhouettes remain recognisably Gaurav Gupta, but without pushing the experimental boundaries of his

metallic breastplates, dramatic origami pleats or exaggerated feathered trains. There is, however, a nod to that side of his work: I am delighted to spot the aerial acrobat opening the show wore the illuminated breastplate from his Divine Androgyne Paris Couture collection unveiled earlier this year.

What deserves closer attention is the craftsmanship. Garments feature

layered embroidery, reflective metallic elements inspired by timepieces, sculpted lace, hand-cut petals and molten crystal embroidery designed to mimic melting glass. Menswear is equally intricate, with sharply tailored sherwanis featuring leopard motifs woven into newly developed Banarasi jacquard techniques.

The final act, Cosmic Union, brought together Benaras brocade and a revival of the label's chikankari craftsmanship. Pearls and crystals layered over ivory and soft white appear across fluid gowns, dramatic cocktailwear and sharply tailored jackets. Actor Ananya Panday closed the show in the Camellia bridal lehenga, a bridal white ensemble embellished with three-dimensional petals and hand embroidery in pearls and crystals.

The evening also marked an extension of Gaurav's design language beyond fashion. At the end of the show, an MG Cyberster was driven around the runway, announcing a collaboration with MG Select, the luxury brand channel of JSW MG Motor India. The designer's signature Serpent Infinity motif, associated with continuity and transformation, will now appear on the MG M9 and MG Cyberster cars. 50 units each of the limited Couture Edition of MG M9 and MG Cyberster will be produced.

Global presence

It has been a landmark year for the designer: a Paris couture showcase in February, Isha Ambani's sculptural sari at the Met Gala, and, most recently, Lady Gaga and Doecheii wearing his crystal-encrusted suits in the music video for 'Runway' from *The Devil Wears Prada 2*.

What keeps him returning to the drawing board season after season?

"I think you simply become a master of your practice, so it gets easier with time. Showing in Paris has given me a new confidence. I'm actually more confident with my Indian clothes now, and that couture culture of Paris has naturally found its way into them."



(Clockwise from left) Crockery crafted at Shantiniketan for Sienna; serving bowls and small plates at Mizu Izakaya; and plates at Firo. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

the stone. While Kamlesh has worked with stone masons in Rajasthan and Mumbai to shape individual stones – often weighing around 200 grams each – into functional tableware that holds heat like a thick-bottomed pan, the process remains sporadic.

An emotional idea

For Vedant Newatia, founder and head chef of Atelier V and Masala Code in Indore, crockery was never meant to be incidental. His collaboration with Jaipur-based Keelamani Studios, a bespoke furniture and interior design firm that also specialises in ceramics, began in 2024 with a clear refusal of anything off the shelf.

"We needed pieces that felt personal to our space – olive tree-inspired servers, custom bread baskets – not standard plates," he says.

For Vedant, crockery shapes the rhythm of a meal. "If a plate doesn't work under pressure, it doesn't belong in our kitchen."

A similar philosophy guides Lakhan Jethani, executive chef and co-founder of Mizu Izakaya in Mumbai. When he began conceptualising Japanese-inspired crockery – at a time when such references were rare in India – Art Ichol, an artist retreat in Maihar, Madhya Pradesh, felt like a natural collaborator.

Working closely with resident ceramic artists, Lakhan developed everything from ponzu bowls to sake ware from scratch. "It was like foraging," he says. "Picking something raw, working on it, and then transforming it."

Crockery, for Lakhan, has always shaped the journey from kitchen to table. Many ask where the plates are from, surprised to learn that nearly half the crockery is exclusive to Mizu.

"It makes the guest feel special," Lakhan says. "That's what this is really about."



Chew on this

CONTINUED FROM
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What first connected Saurabh to these artisans was instinct. "They don't observe trends or references, but Nature, texture, and weight." Many of HOM's plates began as everyday impressions: a pebble from a riverbed, or even a piece of bark picked up on a trek. "Once I said I want a platter that feels like this," he recalls, holding up a bark, "and they understood that language."

The process remains collaborative and experimental with ideas sketched through crushed paper, surfaces debated, even a life-size Hulk-fist platter made and discarded. "It was unusable, but it taught us something." Over time, Saurabh says, he has stopped directing and started listening. "Earlier, I thought of this as craft. Now I see it as thinking through making."

Experimentation is key
Stone has become an unlikely material fixation for Kamlesh



Negi, executive chef and head of research at Naar, Kasauli.

What began as a one-off experiment during foraging-led travels in late 2024 and early 2025 – across Leh, Rishikesh, and the Nubra Valley – has since evolved into a deeper material inquiry. Kamlesh began sourcing stones during these trips, drawn to pieces along riverbanks that felt structurally sound rather than ornamental.

"These aren't soft stones like marble," he says. "They're much denser, and they behave very differently."

That density has proven to be both the appeal and the obstacle. Even stone workers who regularly shape marble – considered relatively forgiving – have struggled. One early attempt ended with a craftsman's machinery breaking under the pressure of carving

Slow sips ahead

Beachville's second outlet in Tiruvannmiyur offers a more laid-back coffee experience



Beachville coffee spread. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Priyamedha Dutta

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Eight years after launching Beachville as a roastery and six years after introducing Chennai to its first roastery cafe, founder Divya Jayashankar has opened a second outpost in the leafy lanes of Tiruvannmiyur.

Tucked inside the same space as The Button Thief Co., an independent label known for its handcrafted everyday clothing, the cafe feels like a natural extension of the label's philosophy. For Divya, the choice was deeply personal. "I grew up in this neighbourhood. My grandparents' house was here, and I've been visiting the store for many years. Since they also believe in slow, sustainable living, it felt like a perfect space to share," she says.

At the heart of Beachville's menu is coffee sourced from estates in Chikmagalur, Coorg, Yercaud, and Biligiri Ranga Hills, which reflects Divya's focus on traceability and origin-driven flavours. The drinks menu blends classic brewing techniques with experimentation. We start with zen, a blend of chamomile-infused milk, filter coffee decoction, and a drizzle of olive oil.

Next is the banana milk latte, made with house-made banana milk, espresso, and topped with a brûléed

banana for a caramelised sweetness.

We then try a clarified latte with a clarified milk base and hints of citrus, and an Attikan pour-over. "This was my way of experimentation and pushing boundaries," laughs Divya.

The food menu is fairly simple. We try the hummus toastie, layered with hummus, cilantro-jalapeno walnut pesto, marinated tomatoes, and pumpkin seeds for a fresh, wholesome bite. The Asian chicken toastie is heartier, bringing together soy-glazed chicken, caramelised pineapple, cumin ricotta, pickled onions, julienned tomatoes, chilli crisp oil, and herbs that pair well with Beachville's brews.

Dessert is what steals the show. The brûléed French toast features a thick slice of brioche topped with Earl Grey Chantilly cream, slivered orange, and black grapes. My favourite is the lemon ricotta pancakes, served with a berry compote and maple-vanilla butter.

"Every dish is inspired by meals we've enjoyed in different places," says Divya.

While the café welcomes its first guests this week, the space is still very much a work in progress. Divya says the interiors will evolve organically as the café settles into its rhythm. "We're still figuring it out as we go along," she says.

The new outlet is at Second Seaward Road, Valmiki Nagar, Thiruvannmiyur. A meal for two is ₹1,500.

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Beyond IVF: The Importance of Fertility Awareness

World IVF Day celebrates advances in reproductive medicine while reminding us that fertility care extends beyond IVF. With one in six people experiencing infertility during their lifetime, timely evaluation, lifestyle changes, treatment of underlying conditions and simpler fertility treatments can help many couples conceive without IVF. Age, particularly in women, significantly influences reproductive potential,



Dr. Sharanya H
Joint Director, Lalithambigai Fertility Centre

while male factors contribute to nearly half of infertility cases. Conditions including PCOS, endometriosis, thyroid disorders, obesity, smoking and untreated infections can affect fertility but are often manageable when detected early. This World IVF Day, let us promote awareness, early diagnosis and personalised care, empowering individuals and couples to make informed reproductive choices.

The Mind-Body Harmony Therapy

At BloomLife Hospital, we believe the journey to parenthood extends beyond clinical excellence, integrating advanced reproductive medicine with a profound understanding of the mind-body connection. This philosophy is the heart of the Mind-Body Harmony Therapy, an exclusive program pioneered by Dr. Kavitha Gautham in Chennai.



Dr. Kavitha Gautham K S
Consultant,
MBBS, MS (OG), FICOG, FIMSA.
BloomLife Hospital

Curated for each couple, the program acknowledges the powerful influence of emotional well-being on fertility. Chronic stress and unresolved emotional challenges can be barriers to conception. Through personalized fertility care, evidence-based treatment, and psychological counselling, the therapy nurtures emotional resilience, empowering couples on their path to parenthood with renewed hope.

When Hope Meets Science, Parenthood Becomes Possible

Infertility affects millions of couples worldwide, with delayed parenthood, lifestyle changes, stress, hormonal imbalances, PCOS, endometriosis and male infertility contributing to rising fertility challenges. Since male factors account for nearly 50% of infertility cases, evaluating both partners is essential. EVA IVF & Women's Centre offers advanced, personalised fertility care, including IVF, ICSI, IUI, fertility preservation, genetic testing, advanced embryology and laparoscopic surgery. With experienced fertility specialists and comprehensive care for male and female infertility, EVA has helped thousands of families begin their parenthood journey. Across its four Chennai centres—Madipakkam, Adyar, OMR and Parrys—EVA continues to make world-class fertility care more accessible.



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The Plurality of Becoming a Parent



No parenthood follows a single, standardised path. As India expands fertility care, the focus is shifting towards accessibility, affordability, awareness and personalised treatment.

Siddhi Nawar

Nature has never followed a single blueprint. A seed may take root in a season of rain, while another waits through a long summer before it blooms. Some flowers open at dawn; others only under the cover of darkness. Yet, each remains part of the same wondrous cycle of life. The journey to parenthood is much the same. For some, it begins effortlessly. For others, it may require time, medical intervention, patience and support. While the desire to become a parent may be universal, the path to parenthood does not look the same for everyone.

This World IVF Day 2026, the theme, “Mission Fertility – Making Fertility Care Accessible to Every Indian,” draws attention to an important truth: access to fertility care should not depend on where a person lives, what they earn or how far they can travel for treatment.

The Dream of Parenthood

Infertility affects approximately one in six people of reproductive age worldwide. Behind every statistic is a deeply personal story: a couple waiting for a pregnancy that does not happen, a woman navigating conditions such as PCOS or endometriosis, a man discovering that male factors may be contributing to infertility, or parents struggling to conceive again after a previous pregnancy. Infertility can affect both men and women, and may be primary or secondary. Regardless of the diagnosis, the emotional experience can be complex. Uncertainty, questions and pressure from families and society can often make an already difficult journey harder.



Fertility Care Is More Than IVF

Nature is wonderfully diverse, and so are the ways in which life unfolds. Not every seed requires the same soil, and not every fertility journey requires the same treatment.

Fertility care encompasses prevention, awareness, diagnosis and treatment. For some, timely medical advice, lifestyle changes or treatment for an underlying condition may be sufficient. Others may require medication, IUI, IVF, ICSI, fertility preservation or other specialised interventions. The right treatment is not the same for everyone. What matters is access to accurate information, timely evaluation and personalised care.

For a city such as Chennai, this conversation is particularly relevant. The city has long been a destination for advanced medical care, including fertility treatment, drawing patients from across Tamil Nadu and neighbouring states. But repeated journeys can bring significant emotional and financial costs, from travel and accommodation expenses to time away from work. Across India, fertility care is therefore evolving. Major centres are expanding into tier-2 and tier-3 cities, while teleconsultations and remote monitoring are helping reduce the burden of repeated travel.

Making Hope More Affordable

Access is not only about geography; it is about affordability too. Fertility treatment can be financially demanding, and financial assistance programmes, flexible payment options, ferti-



ty financing and philanthropic support can help make care more accessible. Because hope should not be reserved for those who can afford to wait.

Perhaps the first step towards accessible fertility care is awareness: understanding that infertility is a medical condition, not a moral failure. Fertility is not solely a woman's responsibility. Men and women can both experience

infertility, seeking help is not an admission of defeat, and no one should have to carry the burden of a fertility challenge in silence. Mission Fertility is ultimately about building a future where a person's postcode does not determine the quality of care they receive, financial limitations do not mean giving up on the dream of parenthood, and fertility is discussed with empathy rather than judgement.

Every fertility journey is different. Every family is formed differently. But the right to seek care, compassion and hope should belong to everyone. Because in the wondrous, unpredictable story of nature, there has never been only one way for life to begin.



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4. Bar Trigona

It is closing time for most shops at Chinatown when we exit Cabinet 8 and head for our last stop of the night, Bar Trigona. Bartender Rohan Matmary, explains that the bar is named after a locally sourced honey that is indigenous to Malaysia. The Trigona bee is stingless and its hive has a different structure than other bee hives, making the honey stay within its hold without dripping down. This leads to a slight fermentation adding an interesting kick to its sweetness. The difference is easily noticeable when I taste the honey before getting into the drinks.

This honey, which is available to buy only at Four Seasons, is also used in some of the cocktails at Bar Trigona. Rohan explains, “Our menu is called The Nectar of Time. My idea of cocktails is that none of them is wrong or right. Its all about when to drink what. The pages in our menu have hourglasses which have different colours, signifying the colour of the sky”

Since it is past 10pm, our menu suggests Nightfall cocktails. “This is the time which is usually not about having refreshing drinks. It is time to have that one good heavy glass and sit at the bar for long without interruption. This section contains stronger drinks that are flavourful where you want the ice to melt into your drink slowly,” Rohan says.

Along with that there is a section called Eternal Hours comprising drinks that can be had at any time of the day.

Rohan suggests a whisky-based cocktail for me, after noticing what I chose throughout the bar crawl. The drink is no-nonsense and heavy-spirited, going along well with Rohan’s explanation of taking it slow.

This cocktail crawl takes you through hidden speakeasies, neighbourhood favourites and inventive bars serving everything from a liquid cheeseburger to cocktails made with stingless Trigona bee honey

Malaysia, stirred and shaken



Shreyas Pande
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Our 30-minute car ride turns into an elaborate guest shift. We take off from the Four Seasons hotel set in the glossy heart of corporate Kuala Lumpur, with dramatic views of the iconic Petronas Towers. Our guide for the evening’s bar crawl is the award-winning bartender who runs Four Seasons’ Bar Trigona, Rohan Matmary, and is friends with everyone behind a bar in the city. Rohan is generously willing to share his contacts and insider tips.



1. Coley

Which is how we get into Coley, set in the southwestern part of the city in Bangsar, a quaint, residential neighbourhood dominated by classic row houses. Sandwiched between two shops, Coley has an unassuming familiarity. The simplicity of its being reflects in its bestselling cocktail: gin blended with coconut water and

served chilled in a mug. Rohan says Coley is the go-to place for locals in the neighbourhood. With dimly lit interiors and limited table seating, the cosy space offers cocktails blended with local flavours, such as Bumi Kita, made with Woodford Reserve bourbon whiskey, pandan leaves and beetroot vermouth.



3. Cabinet 8

After the elegance of Three x Co, it is time for something edgy. Our car comes on a bustling road leading to Chinatown, the city’s centre for local shopping, street food and fancy bars. A host of Chinese and Malay food stalls are busy, cooking with a variety of sauces, meats and vegetables, enveloping the lane in a deliciously tangy aroma.

Cabinet 8 is not easy to find. Sharing its space with another bar, Neighbour Club, reaching the place is filled with an adventure that involves a bookshelf and secret button. We will not give too much away, but this may be easier to find when you are not four drinks down. When we finally get it open, with lots of help from Rohan, we enter a new world, dipped in red light and thudding with pop music. It looks like a scene from a Wong Kar Wai film.

“This is where Gen-Z comes to drink as you get good quality cocktails at a cheaper price,” Rohan says as we settle at a long table just beside the bar. The menu here is designed like a fashion magazine, featuring sleek, neo-noirish photographs of models along with their signature drinks.

There’s an interesting wordplay in some of the cocktails, which are inspired from popular drinks, like the Berry Mary, with the Mexican mezcal, Los Siete Misterios Doba-Yej as the spirit mixed with strawberry, tomato and raspberry vinegar. The result is a sweet mix that has a slightly sour aftertaste. Also among its signatures is the Wild Colada, which is the highlight for me, with its delightful blend of a pineapple smoothie with Bacardi 8. Most of the drinks here are made with local ingredients like guava, kendonang, jackfruit and Sarawak black pepper, all sourced from a Malaysian farm.

Cabinet 8 is now featured on the extended list of Asia’s 50 Best Bars 2026 at number 65.

“We use local flavours and make our drinks with modern techniques,” says head bartender Marcus Kwok as he works with an evaporator machine in the lab situated in a small room inside the bar. This allows finer flavours to be distilled in the spirit. It is also the secret behind their bestselling drink: Double Special. “It is just like a cheese burger but in liquid form. We are able to make it so authentic and flavourful because of this gadget,” says Marcus, patting his evaporator.

The writer was in Malaysia at the invitation of Four Seasons Hotel.

Barry Rodgers

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In a sultry Saturday evening in May, I took the elevator to the 18th floor of The Ritz-Carlton, Pune, home to Agave Lounge, touted as India’s first bar dedicated entirely to agave spirits.

According to the IWSR, India is among the world’s fastest-growing markets for agave spirits. The category recorded 31% year-on-year volume growth and 40% value growth in 2024-25, while sales more than tripled in just four years. Driven by an increasingly sophisticated cocktail culture, tequila has evolved far beyond the sugary shots that once defined it.

Yet agave remains widely misunderstood. Tequila, made exclusively from Blue Weber agave, can only be produced in designated regions of Mexico under a geographical indication (GI). Mezcal, also protected by a denomination of origin, can be distilled from dozens of agave species across specific Mexican states and is often characterised by its smoky profile.

Agave itself is the umbrella category – a family of more than 200 species from which tequila, mezcal and other spirits are distilled.

The menu at Agave Lounge features six agave cocktails. I began with Cacyas, a bright blend of tequila, watermelon cordial, grapefruit, Aperol, St-Germain and lemon juice that balanced citrus, bitterness and floral notes without overwhelming the spirit. Penca, made with tequila, grated coconut, tonka bean and ginger,

was richer and more textured, while the standout, Quiote, layered mezcal with smoky, tropical and tart notes in a clarified cocktail that demonstrated just how nuanced agave can be.

Today, the programme at Agave Lounge is overseen by Beverage manager Damian Goes.

“Education is central to the bar’s identity, introducing guests to the nuances of tequila and mezcal through guided recommendations and conversations at the bar. I believe agave has the potential to become a sophisticated post-dinner drink, much like a fine whisky or cognac, as more consumers begin to appreciate its complexity and depth,” he says.

Across India, a small but growing number of bars are moving beyond simply serving tequila to teaching drinkers about the wider world of agave. Among them is Quinta Cantina in Goa.

Sip it like a single malt

Opened in September 2025 as a 35-seat space in Panjim by beverage expert Pankaj Balachandran and restaurateur Puru Agarrwal, Quinta was designed as an educational bar exploring the shared heritage of Goa’s feni and Mexico’s agave spirits. Everything – from weekly tasting flights and rotating “Agave of the Week” pours to the menu itself – was intended to encourage conversations about provenance, terroir and craft.

“Very few places in India are talking about Tobalá, Espadín, raicilla or the wider world beyond commercial tequila. We wanted people to understand there is an entire category to



Pour decisions

As India’s appetite for premium tequila grows, specialised agave bars are introducing drinkers to the wider world of mezcal and craftsmanship

discover,” says Pankaj.

If bars like Quinta Cantina are cultivating curiosity around agave, producers are beginning to see that interest translate into demand. Among the earliest movers is Maya Pistola Agavepura, launched in 2022 as Asia’s first aged 100% agave spirit. Crafted from wild Agave

americana grown on the Deccan Plateau, the brand has sought to establish a distinct identity for Indian agave rather than positioning itself as tequila.

For founder Rakshay Dhariwal, the biggest shift is how Indians are drinking the spirit. “A few years ago, tequila was largely associated

(Clockwise from left) At the bar inside Agave Room in Delhi; inside Una Hacienda; and a take on Bloody Mary. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



with low-quality mixtos meant for shots. Today, evolved drinkers are sipping 100% agave spirits the way they would a single malt,” he says.

To challenge long-held misconceptions – that agave spirits are only meant to be slammed as shots, or that authentic agave can only come from Mexico – Maya Pistola has invested heavily in bartender training, blind tastings, blending workshops and its Secret Agave Club. The goal is to encourage consumers to see agave as a sipping spirit rather than simply a cocktail ingredient.

The strategy appears to be paying off. Maya Pistola recorded 68% volume growth and 95% growth in net sales value in the last financial year, with Gurugram, Chandigarh and Goa emerging as its strongest markets.

“Tier-I cities and five-star standalone venues are leading the charge,” says Rakshay.

The demand

In Bengaluru, however, Una Hacienda is taking a broader view of Latin America’s drinking traditions. Launched on Lavelle Road in 2025, it does not position

itself as a dedicated agave bar. Founder Arijit Bose has built the programme around Latin America’s diverse spirits – tequila, mezcal, pisco, cachaça and rum.

“People ask for tequila by brand now, and they’re far more willing to experiment with new labels entering the market,” says Arijit. Mezcal remains a more niche proposition because of its price, although Arijit believes India’s affinity for bold flavours gives it enormous long-term potential. Indian agave spirits typically retail for ₹3,500-₹6,000, while imported 100% agave tequilas cost ₹8,000-₹12,000.

Mezcal is pricier still, often ₹10,000-₹16,000, owing to its small-batch production, limited imports and India’s high import duties and State excise taxes.

According to Mexico’s Cámara Nacional de la Industria Tequilera, tequila entering India faces import tariffs of up to 150%, further inflating retail prices.

The question, then, is no longer whether India is ready for agave. It is whether Indian drinkers are ready to discover everything that lies beyond tequila.

To office, to office

Seo In-guk and Park Ji-hyun
revel in the daily workplace grind
in their latest K-drama,
See You At Work Tomorrow

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K-dramas over the years have excelled not just in depicting the daily grind of the workplace, but also in getting their audiences interested in a myriad of lesser-depicted professions on screen. The rush of art auctioneering, the cut-throat world of headhunting, or even the tumultuous challenges in weather forecasting.

In *See You At Work Tomorrow*, which is currently nearing its much anticipated finale, the lead characters, who work for a large electronics company, are tasked with perfecting a home spherical ice maker. Who knew there was so much that went into making crystal-clear ice?

When we sat down for an interview with lead actors Park Ji-hyun and Seo In-guk ahead of the show's release, the workplace experience, of course, came into discussion. A set and a sterile, shiny corporate office might be far removed from being on a set for the same. For them, however, there was much to learn about and to revel in.

"I think I always fantasized about being a corporate employee because it's something I have never experienced personally. I feel like I always envied people who went to work every morning, so being able to, albeit for a short while, live vicariously



Park Ji-hyun and Seo In-guk. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

through my character— you know, live as a corporate employee and wear the office looks, so to speak – it was quite rewarding for me to pretend to be an office worker in that way," says Park Ji-hyun. On the show, Ji-hyun plays Cha Ji-yoon, popularly known as the 'clock-out fairy', since she is as earnest about clocking out as she is about getting her tasks right.

After supporting roles in K-dramas like *Love All Play* and *Reborn Rich*, Ji-hyun burst onto the scene with *Flex X Cop* in 2024, where she played a no-nonsense violent-crimes unit detective, and more recently was nominated for her performance in the coming-of-age drama series, *You and Everything Else*.

Her co-star, Seo In-guk, might play the strait-laced and tsundere Kang Si-woo on the show, but the role, he said, is something he had immense fun playing. "I also have a lot of colleagues, but I think belonging to a group and having people that have your back – I feel like that's very encouraging and motivating," he said. Portraying Kang Si-woo made him think about how it made sense for people to get off work and reward themselves with chicken and beer. "I also wanted to give a huge shout-out to everyone who has to go to work every day because I know that it must be very challenging, although I'm sure it's also fun at times," he added, laughing.

Over the first six episodes, we follow the characters as they navigate workplace politics, meddlesome team leaders, an ensuing existential crisis about work, and, of course, relationship trouble.

Manhwa (comic books or graphic novels) and webtoons have served as inspiration for long and lent themselves to K-drama adaptations. *See You At Work Tomorrow* is based on the hit Kakao Talk webtoon *Back To Work!*, and we asked In-guk what it takes to embody a leading man from a romance that already has a strong fan base.

"Honestly, there's a lot of pressure," he said. "This is my second drama series that was based on a webtoon, and these types of webtoons are created into a live-action series because there are so many fans who loved the original work, right? So I definitely am aware of the weight of the fans' expectations and love."

In-guk said that his basic approach as an actor is to recreate the character from the webtoon exactly as is. "However, I always try to remember to express the particular elements that were loved by fans of the original work, while also trying to create these different characters that may be based on the original webtoon, but maybe exist in a parallel universe," he added.

See You At Work Tomorrow is currently streaming on Prime Video



Richard Gadd in *Half Man*.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

realised that having to return to each episode and recontextualise what the characters had been going through in the intervening years was tough. Exposition is dull and you have to find interesting ways to fill in the gaps between the episodes."

Episode 3 is set in 1993 and there is a 14-year leap to 2008 in episode 4. "So much happens in those 14 years. Ruben goes to prison. He betters himself, comes out of prison and gets a job. Meanwhile, things do not work out for Niall. He's been in a psychiatric hospital. He hasn't dealt with the threat of Ruben's violence well, and these are all hard things to squeeze in. The whole structure of trying to write an almost asymmetrical mosaic structure was hard."

What lies beneath

One of the threads that run through *Half Man* is repression and the suffering it causes. "I've experienced repression and it can be quite toxic. If you're not able to live your true form or within your own happiness or the identity you feel comfortable in, it can lead to extraordinary unhappiness at the very least. In the case of Niall and Ruben, their repression goes on for so long, and they're so violent towards themselves as well as each other that it leads to some destructive and damaging behaviours in their lives."

The levels of bruising physical and psychological violence in *Half Man* make for uncomfortable viewing. "Niall and Ruben are violent people. Ruben's extremely physically violent, and they both enact a certain psychological violence. I wanted to give a sense of context to the struggle both these characters were going through, which made them behave in these incredibly destructive ways."

Repression is an interesting subject to explore, Gadd comments. "A lot of society's ills, certainly over here, come from a lack of acceptance that makes people think they can't speak about things that happen to them, or they can't speak about the way they are, they can't speak about hard, painful feelings they have, but ultimately, speaking and being true to yourself is the key to freedom."

That is what Niall and Ruben struggle with most of all, Gadd says. "They struggle with being true to themselves, being true to one another, showing love for themselves, and showing love for one another, and that in a lot of ways is the key to their destruction."

Half Man is currently streaming on Lionsgate Play

Charting male darkness

Richard Gadd on *Half Man*, its exploration of male repression and violence, and writing the miniseries

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Richard Gadd's *Half Man*, a follow-up to the raw and real *Baby Reindeer*, for which he won three Emmy Awards, is equal parts difficult to watch and impossible to look away from. The six-part British series tells of the toxic relationship between two men, Niall and Ruben, played with fierce fragility by Jamie Bell and Gadd.

Told over 30 years, with Mitchell Robertson and Stuart Campbell playing the younger versions of Niall and Ruben, the series explores complex issues of male violence, addiction and co-dependence.

In the beginning

Speaking from London over a video call, Gadd talks about how *Half Man* came to be. "It was around 2019. There were conversations around male repression and violence and something sparked in me. I remember I was on the tube. I came up with this idea of two men in a barn, with nothing explained or contextualised. One of them is topless, the other is not. One is clearly bigger, burlier and tougher, and they have this conversation. Then you cut back to their lives, and you see them soak up all the prejudices, shame and societal injustices that make them who they are."

That image was all the 37-year-old Scottish writer and comic needed. "I never set out to answer questions, to explore themes, in an 'I'm going to get to the bottom of this', or 'I'm going to say this about this.' All I need is that kick forwards to do something – two broken men in

the present, and the two young adults in the past, who show you the context for why these adults are behaving in the way that they are. That was all I needed to see the project through."

Whose story

While the series is mostly told from Niall's perspective, Ruben is a presence throughout. That is why, Gadd says, it is hard to say whose story it is. "Niall sees Ruben as this godlike presence. Ruben's got the idolatry, the main character syndrome, which is a common phrase these days," Gadd says with a laugh.

The story, Gadd says, is about two brothers, who though not related by blood, have a toxic pull between them. "Things are never straightforward, never black and white. Ruben and Niall have an unexplainable bond. The fact that it's not clear whose story it is shows the tussle they have in trying to be one up on each other. I can never say it is this or that person's story. It's both of their stories, and in a lot of ways, neither of their stories."

Title deed

Though people have asked him what the *Half Man* in the title stands for, Gadd says he does not like to say what things



mean. "I know why it's called *Half Man*. A lot of people come up to me and say, 'Oh, I think it's called *Half Man* because of this or that'. I quite like that people take different things from the title. I don't want to be prescriptive and say this is what I meant. People can take several things from the title."

Ruben even says it at one point in the series, Gadd says. "Niall and Ruben also have things that the other lacks. Celeste (played by Philippine Velge) has a line where she says one of them needs a head, the other needs a body. Together they are whole and empty apart. I'm proud of the title. Funny little fact: for a long period of time, I couldn't quite land on what was right. *Half*

Man came to me quite late in the day, and the second it dropped into me, I thought, 'this feels right to me now'."

Write stuff

Writing *Half Man*, Gadd says, was not easy. "The time pressure was tricky. All I remember is the project was a big, weighty thing. You're coming up against pressure, expectation and some real stiff deadlines. I felt I worked day and night in order to get *Half Man* as good as I possibly could."

The structure of *Half Man* created particular challenges, says Gadd. "Once I decided on these leaps forward in time, with each episode set a few years apart, it became difficult. I



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Malayalam

Missing punch



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Varavu is the kind of film that gives one the feeling that the action sequences were probably planned out first, with an excuse of a storyline added later. Well, there should be a reason for the fights. Can there be a better reason than a good old revenge story of 1990s vintage set in the high ranges? The film is too eager to showcase its fights that by the time we get to know even the name of the protagonist, Paulson (Joju George), two long fight sequences are over.

Shaji Kailas, who is not as prolific these days as he used to be in his heyday, depends on a variant of the run-of-the-mill revenge story for *Varavu*. Paulson is returning home from jail on parole, citing a personal reason, but it is clear that he has a few scores to settle. At the same time, there are quite a few waiting to take him out, evident from the attack by two separate gangs before he even reaches home.

Screenwriter AK Sajan and director Shaji Kailas have individually as well as together tasted blockbuster successes in the 1990s, but over the past two decades, much of their fare has felt dated. Things are not very different in *Varavu*, in which we witness the comeback of a cinematic style that has long lost favour with the audience.

Joju George, who fits well into the character with his world-weary swagger, might have wished this film had been released a few decades ago, when it would have pulled in the masses.

The film does have one element of mystery, related to the disappearance of a character, which could have been used effectively to create some interest in the narrative. But the way this part of the story is presented completely takes out any element of surprise from it. Even when his name is used by another character repeatedly to execute a series of violent acts, no one actually buys his story.

Everything is spelt out clearly by a writer who appears not to want to leave anything to the audience's imagination or let them have any lingering doubts in any scene. The intentions and actions of all the characters are predictable, so much so that even a backstabber does everything short of walking around with a name board saying he is one.

All the typical Shaji Kailas elements appear in the action sequences with an added dose of gore. But without a story to provide the emotional underpinnings for the action, much of it fails to leave a mark, despite Joju's trademark weighty punches.

Varavu is currently running in theatres



A quirky take on family dynamics

Set in rural Telangana, Thiruveer and Aishwarya Rajesh shine in this rural dramedy

Telugu

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In the opening portions of *Oh! Sukumari*, a young girl hears her teacher describe happiness as a large family bound by love and togetherness. Having lost her mother, she quietly holds on to the hope of finding that kind of home someday. Elsewhere, an ageing patriarch mourns a family that seems to value him more for his wealth than his presence. Their shared longing for love and belonging forms the emotional core of the film.

Director Bharath Dharshan brings these seemingly disparate lives together with humour. *Oh! Sukumari* belongs to the recent wave of low-stakes rural comedies that find charm in the everyday lives, dreams and struggles of ordinary people.

Nothing here is larger than life. The village is portrayed without gloss, its homes feel lived-in rather than picture-perfect, and its characters are grounded in reality. Think of Thiruveer's earlier film, *The Great Pre-Wedding Show*, one of 2025's sleeper hits. While that was heavily steeped in humour, *Oh! Sukumari* strikes a more balanced note, pairing laughs with emotional heft.

Set in rural Telangana, the film unfolds in a world of amiable characters who embrace music, dance and colour during village festivities.

What sets *Oh! Sukumari* apart from other rural comedies is the unusual condition of its female protagonist, Sukumari (Aishwarya Rajesh). Whenever she becomes emotional, anyone who touches her receives an electric shock. A

Oh Sukumari

Director: Bharat Dharshan
Cast: Thiruveer, Aishwarya Rajesh
Runtime: 137 minutes

Storyline: A woman with a quirky condition longs for a happy family while the man has to learn to look beyond petty insecurities to find peace.



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childhood incident shows how this strange ability helps her fend off a group of thugs, but as she grows older, the film explores the practical complications it brings.

The village fears Sukumari's condition and keeps her at arm's length, waiting for the day she is married off. Nicknamed *current pilla* (electric girl), she is believed to have no cure – unless she finds a love as calming as the memory of her mother. Her father (Anand) is her solid support, but she yearns for more.

The film takes its time establishing the principal characters, their family dynamics and the emotional baggage they carry. Bharath often frames situations one way before pulling back to reveal a contrasting reality, using humour to soften the reveal. Yadagiri or Yadi's (Thiruveer) political ambitions, for instance, initially paint him as a celebrity before adding greater context. The same narrative device shapes the incidents when he crosses path with Sukumari.

The film is at its most entertaining during the wedding sequence. Seasoned actors Jhansi and Muralidhar Goud enliven the proceedings alongside a vibrant ensemble of villagers, while Bharath Manchiraju's folk-infused contemporary score amplifies the festive mood. The energetic wedding dance is a standout.

The developments here are largely predictable, but the humour lands often enough to keep the narrative engaging. Miscommunication is a familiar plot device, yet it is handled effectively.

As the story shifts to marital conflicts, the film balances comedy with emotional weight without turning too melodramatic. Sukumari's relationships with the women in her marital home, particularly her mother-in-law, played by Aamani, become the emotional anchor using which she begins to address the family's dysfunction.

Not every subplot fares as well. Threads involving rural politics, the insecurities of Yadi's cousin (Srinivas Gavireddy) and another veiled bride add texture, but some outstay their welcome and dilute the narrative's momentum.

The film keeps returning to its protagonists, allowing them space to reflect, make amends and come into their own. It is in the final stretch, however, that the narrative becomes overly talkative. With nearly every character receiving a neatly wrapped-up ending, the 137-minute runtime begins to feel its length. A tighter edit would have helped.

Despite a few missteps, *Oh! Sukumari* remains engaging largely because of Thiruveer and Aishwarya Rajesh. Thiruveer has repeatedly proved his ability to play the everyman, and he does so again with ease. Yadi is layered and flawed, and the actor convincingly navigates his emotional conflicts while effortlessly switching between humour and vulnerability.

Aishwarya, meanwhile, has a knack for making her performances look effortless. She makes the most of the film's comic moments, while also pulling off a mass-action sequence. After *Sankranthiki Vasthunam*, this is another enjoyable addition to her filmography.

Vishnu Oi and Sharanya Pradeep appear in extended cameos. Vishnu arrives at a crucial juncture and leaves an impression, but Sharanya is underserved in a role that offers little for an actor of her calibre.

Oh! Sukumari does not attempt to reinvent rural comedy, apart from the unusual premise surrounding its protagonist. Even so, it delivers a reasonably engaging watch that balances humour and emotion to leave an impression.

Oh Sukumari is currently running in theatres

A tender, bittersweet farewell

English

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For over four years since its debut on Netflix, Alice Oseman's heartfelt ode to teenage love has transported viewers to a near-utopian reality, with a language so refined, sensitive, and honest that it leaves you wondering whether there will ever be another piece of YA fiction that speaks to you with as much empathy and precision. As I write this review of *Heartstopper Forever*, the feature-film finale of the *Heartstopper* series, I yearn to stay a little longer with Charlie Spring (Joe Locke) and Nick Nelson (Kit Connor) in their blanket forts, at park picnics, and on beach dates. As do they.

It's the last year of school for the Truham-Higgs gang, and we take off from the events that closed a rather heavy Season 3. The soft pastel aesthetics, neon doodles, and gentle music take us back to Truham and



Higgs, but as the inevitable end of the road appears, newfound anxieties surface. The fear of eventual separation lurks around the corner, but Oseman ensures the writing eases you into the heaviness at the centre of it all – even if it comes at the cost of occasionally treating high-schoolers with candy-flossy naivety.

Elle Argent (Yasmin Finney) and Tao Xu (William Gao) know in their bones that their chapter might end up in painful parting. Our sweet

friend Isaac Henderson (Tobie Donovan) has embraced his asexual identity, as does Charlie's sister Tori Spring (Jenny Walser), who is in a fulfilling relationship with Michael (Darragh Hand). Imogen Heaney (Rhea Norwood) finds love; after embracing bi-curiosity in the previous season, she now wonders if guys do it for her anymore. Tara Jones (Corinna Brown) and Darcy Olsson (Kizzy Edgell) seem alright as they plan on going interrailing together – and disappointingly,

that's all the space the finale offers them.

The breezy first act introduces our favourite characters so organically that you begin to wonder if the film might end up working even as a standalone feature – except the rest of the film stays with Charlie and Nick so much so that it almost forgets that much of the sheen of that puppy love comes from how the rest of the group go about their lives. The finale has so much to say in so little time that it only hurriedly sprinkles moments of friendship at appropriate points. That said, Oseman's series is known for consistent character writing and weaving emotionally resonant interpersonal arcs, and the film sees the fruit of that effort; a lot gets conveyed effectively with minimal fuss.

Oseman hits a home run especially with how Charlie and Nick are written in the finale. It's nothing short of heroic to see the evolution of Charlie, from a bullied and abused queer kid who was outed forcibly to now being the school's Headboy. Being a good boyfriend is the one

thing that Nick had always been sure about, but as we soon realise, he may not be so sure any longer. After being the gentlemanly emotional pillar of the whole group, Nick is at his most vulnerable in the finale.

Heartstopper Forever

Director: Wash Westmoreland
Creator and writer: Alice Oseman
Cast: Kit Connor, Joe Locke, William Gao, Yasmin Finney, and others
Runtime: 114 minutes
Storyline: As graduation approaches, Charlie, Nick, and their friends navigate love, identity, and the uncertainty of adulthood as they prepare to leave school behind.

As it has always done for over three seasons, *Heartstopper Forever* speaks of teen love and queer love through refreshingly sensitive lenses and offers a nuanced look at how identity, mental health, allyship and friendship intersect.

The finale might invite the same criticisms that previous seasons of the show have attracted – like playing it safe with sanitised sex scenes and a few seemingly big emotional conflicts resolving sooner than expected – but Oseman's is a show that has repeatedly championed hope over hopelessness and love over hate.

Towards the end of *Heartstopper Forever*, an elderly gay couple have tea at the cafe Charlie works in, and as it does for Charlie, watching them made me drift ahead to a future where Charlie and Nick are together and well. Of course, relationships may not last. But love sustains, now and forever.

Heartstopper Forever is currently streaming on Netflix

Ride or Die

Creator: Tessa Coates

Cast: Octavia Spencer, Hannah Waddingham, Ed Skrein, Calam Lynch, Savannah Steyn, Jamie Parker, Sylvia Hoeks, Bill Nighy, Jacky Ido

Episodes: 8

Runtime: 48–55 minutes

Storyline: Two lifelong friends, while on the run from some very bad people, discover shocking truths about each other.



Globe-trotting fare

English

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The retired assassin seems to be a constant fixture in action movies, and, in *Ride or Die* we have a different kind of killer. The series opens with Judith (Hannah Waddingham), disregarding her handler Sam’s (Calam Lynch) instructions to very publicly kill a nasty Russian. When she meets Sam after the mission, he tells her the firm has decided to retire her as she is a WOACA (Woman of a certain age).

Judith demands another chance, which Sam reluctantly arranges. Besides Judith’s mission that goes spectacularly wrong, we also see her best friend, Debbie

(Octavia Spencer), the American wife of a British MP, David (Jamie Parker). Debbie loves shopping for antiques and plotting her husband’s rise to the premiership and 10 Downing.

Debbie has no idea about Judith’s secret profession, believing her to be a forensic accountant, a profession that sounds so boring as to kill any further questions, according to Judith. Judith’s latest job – doing away with Billy Donovan (Ed Skrein), from a crime syndicate, takes her to a gala, and into the path of Debbie and David. All hell breaks loose as bodies, truths and half lies tumble with alarming frequency and end up with a furious Debbie on the run with Judith.

Through eight episodes, the two friends hurtle from Britain, Calais, Barcelona, Monaco, to Lyon, Geneva, Turkey and Mexico City, with Judith’s vengeful former work colleague, as well as a

blood-thirsty Albanian mob and the Interpol in the form of courtly Jacques (Jacky Ido) on their tail.

There is mob money (£24 million) involved and all sorts of wild schemes to return it as well as corruption in high places. *Ride or Die* moves at a quick pace and the chemistry between Spencer and Waddingham has a charming lived-in feel. Spencer’s Debbie despite not having Judith’s elite training has common sense and decency to get the duo out of many sticky situations.

Bill Nighy is all silky sinister as the all-powerful Director and Judith’s employer. Skrein revels as the charming bad boy while Sylvia Hoeks, as the antagonist, is on the right side of destructive with her manic smile and tightly coiled energy.

The kind of glamour one has come to expect from these globe-trotting shows is there in every gleaming fixture of the Royal Andalusian Express, which the two friends take from Calais to Barcelona, where

some more bodies and truths pile up.

There are fun details like the *Lord of the Rings* password required to enter the money man’s house being dismissed as “Nordor”, and the ease with which a character is tracked via social media feeds – Smiley would have been horrified.

Books feature in *Ride or Die* – fairly unusual for an action series. Apart from *The Lord of the Rings*, and the book club Judith and Debbie are part of, there is also mention of Judith being the first female assassin, when she slayed the Assyrian general, Holofernes. The Black Spot from *Treasure Island* also gets a starring role. It is interesting that *Ride or Die* is bookended by *The Book of Judith* and *The Song of Deborah*, both from The Old Testament. If books are not your thing, there is always good acting, energetic chases and ballistic shootouts to keep you amused.

Ride or Die is currently streaming on Prime Video

Snippets



A defining chapter

Prime Video has announced that its original movie *Phoolan* has been selected for a Special Presentation at the 51st edition of the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF), which will run from September 10 to 20, 2026. The film will be showcased at the festival on September 16 at the Princess of Wales Theatre.

Inspired by the book *I, Phoolan - The Autobiography of India’s Bandit Queen*, by Phoolan Devi, the film tells the story of a defining chapter in her life, where thousands of men trap her in a village in an attempt to kill her. A Namah Pictures production, the Hindi action drama is written and directed by the critically acclaimed director Richie Mehta and produced by Shareen Mantri Kedia, Kishor Arora, Kanwal Kohli, and Richie Mehta.

Sneha Kumari essays the titular role and is supported by Anurag Thakur, Vikram Pratap Singh, Aakash Dahiya, Prateek Pachori, and Dev Dutt Budholiya.



All eyes on Nivin

Here is something for Nivin Pauly fans to look forward to this Onam. *Bethlehem Kudumba Unit*, a Bhavana Studios production directed by Gireesh AD will be released on August 21. The film rides high expectations not just for its line-up of actors, including Mamitha Baiju opposite Nivin, but also for Sangeeth Prathap, Vinay Forrt, and Suresh Krishna. Gireesh helmed the hugely successful *Premalu* (2024); the co-writer on this project is Kiran Josey. The other technicians include Vishnu Vijay (music), Ajmal Sabu (cinematography), and Akash Joseph Varghese (editing).



Spread the joy

The makers of *Varanasi* revealed two looks of Priyanka Chopra Jonas from the film. Directed by SS Rajamouli, the pan-Indian project stars Mahesh Babu in the lead.

In one poster, the actor is seen in an intense avatar. Sporting a black outfit, Priyanka appears stylish. In another poster, the actor is seen as a joyful individual, against an epic backdrop of misty blue-grey mountains. Giraffes and zebras are also seen in the background. The actor is jumping with joy, with arms stretched wide.

Varanasi, produced by SS Durga Arts and Showing Business, is set to hit the screens on April 07, 2027. Prithviraj Sukumaran essays the role of the antagonist in the movie. Billed as a “globetrotter”, the movie is touted to blend a cosmic disaster with ancient Indian mythology.



The journey home

Christopher Nolan’s expansive film also proves to be his most revealing, folding three decades of recurring obsessions into the story that may have inspired them all

English

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It remains one of literature’s longest-running debates whether Homer was ever a person at all, or simply the accumulated voice of generations of storytellers gradually refining the same epic homecoming across centuries. Three thousand years since their time, one of the most defining storytellers of the modern age has finally found his way to that very tale, bringing with him a film that feels, in every conceivable sense, like the cumulative expression of everything his career has been converging upon. The Fates conspired to bring Christopher Nolan to *The Odyssey*. Or perhaps it was the other way around. Either way, it is difficult to imagine a filmmaker better equipped to shoulder Homer’s poem into the 21st century.

The acclaimed Academy Award-winner has now reached the rarefied cultural tier where every one of his major motion picture events arrive pre-canonised in the cultural consciousness (nowhere more fervently than in India). But his adaptation of the age-old homecoming epic does something almost perverse for his most loyal *bhakt*s, peeling away much of the conceptual self-regard that has defined most of his work and discovering a version of himself that feels calmer, more reflective and surprisingly modest.

Based on the foundational Greek epic traditionally attributed to Homer, *The Odyssey* follows the legendary war hero Odysseus on his arduous decade-long voyage home to Ithaca after the Trojan War, as monsters, gods and his own fatal flaws repeatedly frustrate his return. Nolan adapts Emily Wilson’s more digestible translation of the poem with Matt Damon as the wily king of Ithaca, alongside Tom Holland as his son Telemachus, Anne Hathaway as his steadfast wife Penelope, and a sprawling ensemble that includes Zendaya, Lupita Nyong’o, Robert Pattinson, Charlize Theron, Jon Bernthal, Himesh Patel, John Leguizamo and Samantha Morton.

The Odyssey

Director: Christopher Nolan

Cast: Matt Damon, Tom Holland, Anne Hathaway, Zendaya, Lupita Nyong’o, Robert Pattinson, Charlize Theron, Jon Bernthal, Himesh Patel, John Leguizamo, Samantha Morton

Runtime: 173 minutes

Storyline: Odysseus embarks on a dangerous voyage back to Ithaca following the Trojan War

Nolan opens the story at the end of another. Troy has fallen, the victors have long since sailed home, and Odysseus remains marooned somewhere between myth and memory after twenty years away from Ithaca. His return unfolds through a fractured chronicle of terrors, temptations and old sins, while back home Penelope and Telemachus struggle to hold together a kingdom slowly being consumed from within by opportunistic suitors.

Looking back at his filmography, it’s difficult to decide whether *The Odyssey* represents a departure for Nolan or the oldest film he has ever made. He has spent the better part of three decades making films about men simply trying to get home. Sometimes that journey cuts through fractured memory, sometimes through dreams, black holes, collapsing timelines or history itself, yet it almost always circles the same anxiety that whatever waits at the end may no longer recognise the person returning to it.

The richness of this adaptation is in its double act of translation. Nolan renders the epic startlingly prosaic and his instincts repeatedly tug Homer toward modernity. He domesticates the ancient poem into something emotionally legible for contemporary audiences, though deciding whether that amounts to translation or sanitisation proves considerably more rewarding than litigating fidelity to Homer.

Matt Damon ultimately carries that reinterpretation through one of the strongest performances of his career. Homer’s favourite epithet for the titular hero Odysseus, was *polymetis* (the man of many wiles), which in hindsight feels custom-built for Damon. Be it Jason Bourne, Tom Ripley, Colin Sullivan, Dr. Mann, or even Will Hunting; he seems drawn to men who survive by cunning and deception, and *The Odyssey* finally gives that screen persona its patron saint. Nolan exploits that accumulated screen history beautifully, allowing us to project those earlier performances onto an Odysseus whose brilliance repeatedly condemns both himself and everyone unfortunate enough to trust him.

Tom Holland too, benefits enormously from approaching heroism sideways. Freed from the obligations of wearing

latex, Holland finally gets to approach the Hero’s Journey from the wings instead of the centre of the stage, which gives him considerably more to chew on.

The Odyssey likewise boasts one of the strongest ensembles Nolan has ever assembled. Himesh Patel and John Leguizamo are some of the film’s revelations, each carving memorable, deeply human performances from roles that exist largely to orbit Odysseus’ legend. But the less said about the now obligatory casting discourse, the better. Discovering a sudden passion for Bronze Age ethnography only when a Black woman is cast as Helen feels disgustingly convenient, particularly in a film where literally nobody is Greek. If anything, Lupita Nyong’o’s Helen has already managed to start a war before the film has even opened, and Homer would probably consider that inspired casting.

A scene-stealing Samantha Morton walks away with the film. Her Circe ranks among the year’s great supporting turns, elevating one of *The Odyssey*’s most gruesome episodes into a nightmarish showcase of practical body horror. The fact that Nolan achieves the entire sequence physically only makes it more astonishing.

Amidst Scylla, Charybdis, the Sirens, the Laestrygonian giants and even the depths of Hades itself, Nolan’s vision still gravitates toward engineering problems more instinctively than relying on the willing suspension of disbelief that fantasy offers. Fortunately, Hoyte van Hoytema and Ludwig Göransson keep pulling the film back toward sensory exhilaration.

The film’s gripping final act, anchored by a previous Trojan Horse sequence that carries the same dreadful inevitability as *Oppenheimer*’s Trinity Test, suggests Nolan is still working through many of the same political anxieties.

It’s almost radical, finding a blockbuster of this magnitude remain unwilling to narcotise its audience with the lotus flowers of cheap, easy entertainment, but I’m still uncertain whether it’s Nolan’s finest film, or even his most accessible. It is, however, the film that finally explains why the rest of his filmmaking journey looks the way it does.

The Odyssey is currently running in theatres

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